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Why We Came to Think as We Do

We did not make the ideas we live by. They are, for the most part, ideas we inherited, unthinkingly growing into patterns of thought cultivated by others, with little sense of why just these ways of seeing, valuing, and reasoning should have gained hold in the first place. Some ideas, like that of *water*, may be so plainly useful for creatures like us as to appear inevitable. But many of our most venerable ideas—such as *truth*, *knowledge*, or *justice*—are highly abstract, and their practical value for us is elusive. Why did these ‘highest concepts’, these ‘last wisps of smoke at the evaporating end of reality’ (*TI*, Reason, §4), as Nietzsche called them, ever become so important to us? What was the point of coming to think in terms of these grand abstractions, and what would we lose if we lacked them?

Such *Pragmatic Questions* about the practical origins of ideas have seldom been raised. They have tended to be side-lined by more traditional *Socratic Questions* of the form ‘What is X?’ Aiming straight at the essence of truth, knowledge, or justice, the Socratic approach reckons that if only we achieve clarity about what these things really are, an understanding of why we came to be concerned with them will follow. Socratic Questions can prove obstinately vexing, however, and a consensus on what truth, knowledge, or justice are has yet to emerge. Accordingly, some have concluded with the American pragmatist C. S. Peirce that ‘we must not begin by talking of pure ideas—vagabond thoughts that tramp the public highways without any human habitation—but must begin with men and their conversation’ (1931, 8.112). Peirce, like the philosophers I discuss in this book, diagnosed a tendency in philosophy to set ideas too high above human affairs, to contemplate them entirely *in vacuo*. Ideas are in their element in distinctive contexts of purposive human action, action that takes place against a background of contingent facts about us and the world we live in. Trying to understand the ideas we live by in isolation from the circumstances in which they are felicitously deployed is like studying a shoal of beached fish as if they were in their natural habitat.

Instead, we can turn the order of explanation around and let the *what* grow out of the *why*: we approach the question of the nature of truth, knowledge, or justice by first asking why we came to think in these terms. Such an inquiry into the origins of ideas can take many guises. Plato asked after the origins of ideas, but he sought them in an abstract realm of Forms. Conceptual historians of various stripes asked after the origins of ideas, but they sought them by tracing the changing